

THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with President Carlos Andres Perez of Venezuela on December 17, 1991 (S)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
President Carlos Andres Perez of Venezuela
Interpreter: Stephanie Van Reigersberg
Notetaker: John F. McShane

DATE, TIME: December 17, 1991, 3:21 - 3:55pm EST
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President: CAP, how are you? (S)

President Perez: What a pleasure to hear from you, Mr. President. (S)

The President: How are you doing? (S)

President Perez: I'm fine, thank you. I was waiting to call you about the situation in Haiti until I had a clear picture of the situation there. Now I can give a definitive picture. (S)

The President: Please do. (S)

President Perez: I think we have reached a decisive moment and there is a great risk of violence exploding if a decision is not taken quickly. After all the work your people have done, and Aronson has done extraordinary work on the issue for several weeks--without the work of the United States we would have failed--now we have reached a difficulty that I think requires your (personal) intervention to resolve. (S)

The President: Okay. (S)

President Perez: First, I want to tell you that Aristide has changed a great deal during his stay here in Caracas. He recognizes his mistakes of the past and is no longer an intransigent man. (S)

However, we still have one big difficulty in choosing a new Prime Minister. Despite all the efforts of your Ambassador and Aronson, the whole process has become stuck. The problem is that despite the fact that Bazin is the most competent person in Haiti, he is not the appropriate choice for Prime Minister. (S)

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The fact that he went on TV after the coup in support of it and his enmity toward Aristide have undercut his possibilities. It really is impossible for Aristide to accept him and even more impossible for the friends of Aristide in Haiti to accept him. And if we continue to insist on him we will be wasting our time completely. (S)

The case of Victor Benoit as the Prime Minister does not seem possible either--although he has support from 47 people in the lower house, he has the support of only 12 of 29 in the upper house. (S)

In my talks with the OAS Commission and its Chairman, Ramirez Ocampo, we concluded that we have to go back to Rene Theodore who was under consideration at the outset. (S)

At the beginning Aristide would not accept Theodore because Theodore was head of the Communist Party--and Aristide thought it (putting Theodore's name forward) was a trap to show that he was being intransigent. So we have convinced Aristide to accept Theodore and Ramirez Ocampo is prepared to ask the Congress to propose him to Aristide. (S)

The President: You're talking of Theodore? (S)

President Perez: Yes, Theodore. The problem is that your Ambassador Adams keeps on insisting that Bazin must be the candidate because he is the only one the Army will accept. I spoke with Adams at great length on Saturday and I realized that he is extremely tough, and does not want to accept anyone except Bazin. (S)

He keeps saying that Bazin is the only person that the Army will accept but this position is not acceptable because we cannot let the Army dictate the entire process. The problem is that we cannot just go on talking--as I know you know, two of Aristide's supporters were killed on Sunday and they set fire to Aristide's house and Aristide's mother's house. (S)

My proposal is that the OAS go immediately to Port-au-Prince and stay there until a solution is made because a catastrophe is impending. The chairman of the OAS Commission--Ramirez Ocampo--agrees with this solution and is only awaiting your opinion before going. He also understands that there is no time to waste and that the situation is very dangerous. (S)

Finally, I would like to say to you, Mr. President, with all sincerity, that this is indeed the best solution. I'm sure Aronson would agree with me. I think that he has worked so well. I think that perhaps Ambassador Adams has a different position. (S)

The President: Well, let me make a couple of comments. First, we are grateful to you for your leadership and interest in getting a solution. We totally agree on the urgency of getting this situation solved now. (S)

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And we agree that after we reach agreement on a Prime Minister the OAS should go right away. But it is fundamental that the Prime Minister be acceptable to the Army as well as the Parliament. (S)

You are right that we strongly support Bazin as the most able man and the only person with the capacity to ensure the military and the opposition. Clearly we need a Prime Minister who can assure that if Aristide comes back there won't be another coup within a matter of days. Thus our preference is to propose Bazin and get Aristide to compromise. Even though he supported the coup and--what was the second thing you mentioned--and that there is enmity between him and Aristide, in spite of that he is still our first choice. (S)

However, on Theodore we have problems with his Communist past, but understand he may have changed his stripes. He reportedly now talks free-market economics and privatization. But we don't believe that he has support in the rank and file of the army even though he stood up to Aristide on human rights abuses. (S)

But, we are not going to stand in the way of Theodore if he has wide spread support, and we have assurances from somewhere that he will have the support of the Congress and the military so that there won't be another coup three days later. I don't think you want a Prime Minister who will be gone in two or three days. (S)

My question to you, CAP, my friend, is how can we demonstrate that Theodore has that support? (S)

President Perez: Mr. President, I agree with you that the best solution was to have Bazin as Prime Minister. He is the only Haitian I know who has clear ideas about the situation there and what to do about it. I've spoken to him various times in the past. I had a long conversation with Aristide the day of his inauguration and that day urged him to work closely with Bazin. I got President Carter to do the same, but unfortunately we didn't succeed. (S)

And then there developed a profound dislike between the two men. (S)

I think you will recall that in Caracas I told you that it was too bad that Bazin wouldn't win because it would be better for him to win, but now my dear friend, we are confronting realities and must address them. I wouldn't be pressing you if I thought there was another way out. (S)

On Theodore, I am basing my arguments on the same information that Aronson has. Of course I don't have the information to guarantee that the military will accept him but Aronson did include him two weeks ago among the people the Army might accept. (S)

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The person who was against him was Aristide. Aristide was against him because he was a Communist, and it hasn't been easy to get Aristide to accept him. Ramirez Ocampo does think he will get the necessary support. (S)

The President: From both the Congress and the Army? (S)

President Perez: Yes, but of course we need strong support from you, and someone to adopt a very strong position there--either Adams or someone you would send down there to push the army. (S)

I want to tell you that I found Adams tough, inflexible, stubborn. I talked with him at Aronson's suggestion but I couldn't change his position by a millimeter. I know that he had a tough job. I don't know if you want to send someone else like Mr. Kozak who worked on the Panama problem to help Adams carry out the new demarche. I'm convinced this is a very tough job. (S)

The President: But CAP, do you see the job as trying to get the OAS to convince the Congress and the Army to accept Theodore? Is that the next step? (S)

President Perez: The next step is that the OAS Commission--Mr. Ramirez Ocampo--would leave tomorrow. He is ready to do this. And then the Commission begins by dealing with Congress first--and the Congress would exert pressure on the Army which at one point in the past did not object to Theodore. Although I'm still convinced strong pressure needs to be put on the Armed Forces. (S)

Then I think the success of the enterprise depends on actions of a group led by you, the Canadians, and Venezuela. (S)

The President: Let me get Scowcroft to check with Aronson--Baker is out of town--if Theodore is acceptable to the military and Parliament, we will reluctantly go along. (S)

President Perez: Magnificent, Mr. President. That is all I could ask for. That's all I wanted to ask for. I will talk with Aronson. I get along with him well. (S)

The President: That's fine, but I'm not sure what the next step is. If we have to sell the military on Theodore that could be difficult. (S)

President Perez: Mr. President, you have done things much more difficult.

The President: Let us get back to Aronson. Are you in Caracas? Aronson will call. (S)

President Perez: Yes, I'm here in Caracas. (S)

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The President: My bottom line is that, if Theodore is acceptable to the army and Congress, we will reluctantly go along with the deal. I find it difficult to go along with a Communist. Let's hope like hell he isn't one. (S)

President Perez: It's even harder for Father Aristide. (S)

The President: Of course, as you know, we think he is a difficult person. What is important for us is the principle. A democratically elected leader should not be thrown out, but this political leader doesn't inspire great confidence. (S)

President Perez: We agree on that, Mr. President, although I assure you I have engaged in a serious teaching exercise here in Caracas that was difficult but very successful and he has learned alot. (S)

The President: Yes, let me get working on this up here now and we'll get back to you soon. (S)

President Perez: George, let me wish you and Barbara a very Merry Christmas. (S)

The President: Feliz Navidad. (S)

President Perez: Merry Christmas and see you soon. (S)

-- End of Conversation --

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